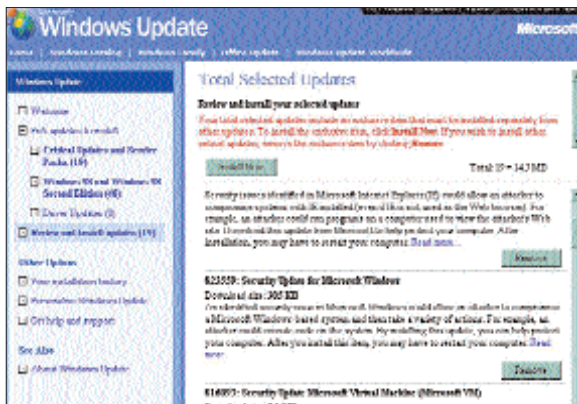




Check for Windows updates at the Windows Update Web site

Symantec, one of the best known security firms, regularly announces its findings at <http://securityresponse.symantec.com>. They also have a security-related e-mail service. Similarly, McAfee too gives security updates at <http://us.mcafee.com/virusinfo>. One interesting feature of this Web site is its virus calendar, with which you can find which viruses are active on any given date. This is really helpful, as it helps track viruses that lay dormant until a particular date, and informs you on how to track and tackle them.

A common misconception is that open-source operating systems are free from vulnerabilities. Whether open source software are more secure or not is a different subject altogether; what you need to do is plug all the holes, in whatever operating system you use. With Linux, a vulnerability is usually listed with complete technical details—not something the average user needs. Red Hat announces its security updates at www.redhat.com/apps/support/errata.

to both software companies and users.

Computer Emergency Response Team - Coordination Center (CERT-CC) is an agency that was set up to address the security concerns of the Internet. CERT was established by the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA)—the developers of the ARPANET which subsequently became the Internet. All their announcements are made by CERT at www.cert.org. This is a comprehensive Web site for security, and doesn't merely list the latest discoveries—it also provides information on how to secure systems. A notable incident was one that occurred in September 2003—Microsoft had released a patch for a security flaw in IE 6. CERT posted this before Microsoft did, who obviously wanted to wait until

ta. Similarly, SuSE makes its security announcements at www.suse.de/us/private/support/security.

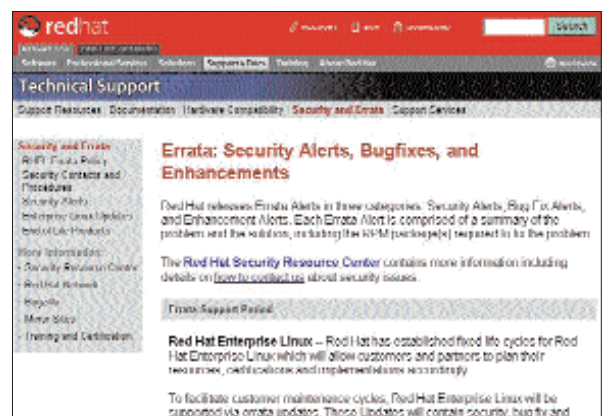
Nothing official about it

Official sites may not list vulnerabilities unless they also have patches for the same, but there are many other sites that do. These sites allow anyone to report vulnerabilities in any software. Once the vulnerability is verified, they post it on their Web site as a warning

they had developed a working patch.

One of the most well-known sites in this realm is www.packetstorm.nl. Packet Storm is maintained by a group of security professionals who believe that full disclosure is the only way to ensure the development of secure software. The site has a forum to discuss security issues, and is categorised into sections on Unix, Windows, Intrusion Detection, etc. You can post questions in the relevant forum, or just read through them to gain a lot of information on how to find vulnerabilities and patch them. On the home page, you'll find the current Top 20 advisories, exploits and tools. In the advisory section, the vulnerabilities discovered are listed along with the code for exploiting the flaw. The tools section contains security-related utilities. This site is a definite must for people who need the complete technical details, as well as for those keen on learning the finer points of security.

Secunia (www.secunia.com) is another comprehensive security Web site that has



Red Hat security announcements aren't very user friendly

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